Insights from *How to Take Smart Notes* by Sönke Ahrens

Don't leave this world with valuable knowledge in your head, notebook, or note-taking application. Take what you've learned (or are currently learning) and turn it into something useful by adopting the "Zettelkasten" note-taking system. The "Zettelkasten" note-taking system was invented by German sociologist Niklas Luhmann. Luhmann used the system to write 58 books and over 500 academic papers in his lifetime by averaging just six notes a day.

The Zettelkasten system seems like a primitive system of index cards and boxes but is has a remarkable way of gathering and organizing notes so that writing the first draft of a book, academic paper, business plan, or article is effortless. Here are two primary reasons the Zettelkasten system is different and better than traditional note-taking systems:

Advantage #1: Two-stage filter to prevent mediocre ideas from diluting existing notes.

Capture interesting information from books, lectures, articles, or podcasts, and ideas that come to mind throughout the day (stage 1). I use Evernote, but you can capture ***literature notes*** and ***fleeting notes*** in any note-taking application you choose (Apple notes, Google Keep, Notion, or in a simple notepad in your pocket). Capturing fleeting and literature notes is like collecting interesting artifacts on a hike and putting them in your backpack to look at later.

Then, once a day (preferably at the same time each day), go through your metaphorical backpack of literature notes and fleeting notes from the past 24 hours, and determine which notes you should convert to ***permanent notes***.

Ask yourself two questions when determining if you should make a note permanent:

1. ***Does this note produce a similar level of excitement as when I first captured it?*** *I often have brilliant ideas in a caffeinated state at a coffee shop, but when I review my notes at home in a non-caffeinated state, most of the ideas I captured are useless.*
2. ***Does this note add value to other permanent notes?*** *If an idea is not critical to your project or does not expand your understanding of a topic in your Zettelkasten system, do not waste time converting it to a permanent note).*

If an idea or piece of information passes those two criteria (very few will), make it a permanent note by rewriting the note on an index card (I suggest using 4x6 index cards). When you rewrite a note, try to incorporate existing ideas. By finding ways to connect new ideas to existing ideas, you expand your web of knowledge, deepen your understanding, and boost your creativity. As Steve Jobs said, **"Creativity is just connecting things."** And when you are forced to handwrite notes on index cards, you're forced to slow down, clarify your ideas, and express your ideas in as few words as possible (which will save you time when you write your first draft).

Advantage #2: Bottom-up approach to deepen understanding and generate new insights.

Most people take a top-down approach to researching by outlining their book, article, or school paper, and then gathering information. However, having a structured outline too early will discourage you from exploring ideas outside your structure. The Zettelkasten system is a bottom-up researching system that allows you to follow your curiosity and generate keywords as you gather notes. Overtime, your list of keywords organically turns into an interesting outline for your project.

Adopt a bottom-up approach to your research and writing by adding three things to every permanent note:

1. A **location code** prefixed to the title
   - *Prefix the title of every permanent note with a location code to easily sort and reference your notes. The first note you add to your Zettelkasten system will have a "1" prefixed to its title, and your second note will have a "2" prefixed to its title. If your third note builds on the first note, place it between notes "1" and "2," with the code "1A" prefixed to its title. If you have notes, "1A" and "1B," and wish to insert a note between those two notes, it will have the code "1A1." And if you insert a note between "1A1" and "1A2," its code will be "1A1A." Notice a pattern?*
2. A list of **keywords** in the top right corner
   - *Keywords are like Twitter hashtags in that they group notes together and are used to quickly find relevant notes. Aim to add one to three keywords to the top right corner of every permanent note. Identify keywords by asking yourself: "**What is one word or phrase that will relate this note to an existing note?"***
   - *When you come up with a new keyword or phrase, put it on your "**Master Index**" located at the front of your index card box. The **Master Index** includes keywords and phrases with location codes (like "3A1") you can use when determining where you should insert new notes. Continuously update your "master index" with keywords and use your "master index" to outline your first draft.*
3. **Links** to permanent notes in the bottom right corner
   - Often a permanent note will have many potential friends in your Zettelkasten system. For example, if a new note could fit nicely behind note "12A1" and have the code "12A2," but it also relates to notes "2B1" and "24B," don't spend too much time debating where the note should go. Simply code the note "12A2" and write down location codes to related notes in the bottom right corner of the note so you can review these links when you write your first draft. Finding links to notes in other parts of your Zettelkasten system is a great way to expand your web of knowledge and spark new ideas that improve your book, school paper, or article.

When your research phase is over, go through your Zettelkasten system sequentially, one card at a time, and effortlessly write your first draft.